

provide a printout for the faxes. This is called the secure receiving mode, wherein all incoming faxes are stored in the MFD's memory. You can later access the MFD, and print the faxes by punching in the password you provided earlier when configuring the MFD.

For system administrators, such MFDs can also provide detailed prints about fax usage on the particular MFD. You can get a report about the phone numbers stored in the MFD's memory, a sent-fax report, received-fax report and more.

Some MFDs also have a power failure report generator that automatically generates a report after restoration of the device from a power failure.

Similar to e-mail spam, there are people who randomly send junk faxes to other fax numbers. If your fax machine receives junk faxes regularly, use the junk fax barrier feature through which you can specify upto 10 fax numbers as junk.

Any incoming faxes from these junk numbers are blocked from being printed, and are included in the generated received-fax report.

These were some of the features available on most high-end laser-based MFDs. The manner in which you access them will vary for various MFDs.

Take Your Pick

Laser-based MFDs can be broadly classified into three distinct categories—Personal, Workgroup and Heavy Duty, and cater to a specific segment.

Personal MFDs contain devices that are sheet-fed, and have limited scanning abilities. Most are monochrome scanning devices restricted to 256-colour grayscale scanners.

Some are actually fax machines, with laser printing and scanning capabilities built around them. They are best suited for very low print volumes, as the cost per page is high.

Workgroup MFDs utilise a laser-printing engine. The consumable used is a unified toner cartridge. The toner life is usually 3,000 pages, and a drum is said to last for 7,000 pages. The

toner and drum are in a sealed cartridge, so when your toner is used up, you have to replace the entire cartridge including the half-used drum.

Heavy-duty MFD technology is the same as copier machines, which are quite rugged. Here, the toner is stored in a separate cartridge from the drum; so you only replace what you use up. Typically, a drum is rated to last for 50,000 pages, and the toner lasts for about 5,000 pages. So, a copier-based MFD actually works out cheaper in the long run.

Personal MFDs

In small offices, devices with a smaller footprint are preferred over huge machines. Due to the absence of a flatbed scanner, sheet-fed MFDs score in terms of space, and do the same job as their bigger counterparts.



Such MFDs are recommended for work environments where space is at a premium, and also for professionals who carry work home. A small footprint and greater usability make these devices a good option for getting work done faster.

Workgroup MFDs

For a low to medium volume of printing and copying, MFDs based on laser printer engines are preferred. These are generally deployed as shared resources in departments. These MFDs can handle a fair amount of work-load and also provide fast-paced printing and copying.

Heavy-duty MFDs

Heavy-duty MFDs are good for high volumes of printing and copying, have low running

costs, are rugged and offer longer duty cycles. They are costlier and generally meant for large firms.

These MFDs are the best in the laser-based category, and offer a host of additional features.

The MFD Buying Guide Before Buying An MFD

Consider your usage pattern: if you print and copy a lot, choose a copier engine-based MFD. If you print more and copy less, opt for a printer engine-based MFD. If fax is your main concern, opt for a specialised laser fax that doubles as a laser printer and scanner.

Look for handy features such as paper capacity, buffer memory, duplex printing, and toner save. Ensure that the MFD can print on the type of paper products you use, say, envelopes or index cards.

Consider upgradeability and scalability, as these options will extend the life of the device. Being bulky, lugging laser MFDs around is not feasible. Make sure your model is covered by an on-site warranty.

Try the console interface to figure out how to operate the device. Examine the control panel. It should have a good LCD panel to display status messages and warnings.

Some More Functions

You can scan multiple documents in batch processing mode or optionally, use Optical Character Recognition to convert scanned documents and faxes into text documents for editing.

On some MFDs, you can save the received fax on the PC and print only the required faxes.

If your machine is out of paper, or the ink cartridge is low, faxes will be stored in the 'fax memory'. When the paper tray is refilled or the cartridge is replaced, then the stored faxes will be printed. Some MFDs can store up to 500 pages.

Use the 'PC Faxing' option if you would like to send faxes directly from your computer's modem without having to print the document and feeding it manually into the fax machine. ■

bhaskar_banik@thinkdigit.com